



“I am very passionate about AI. For instance, we have seen a dramatic increase in weighted forecast accuracy. We have several decades of insights and proprietary data”

Q: What is the plan as far as the investment in Forest Essentials is concerned?

A: When we invested in Forest Essentials in 2008, it had two stores. Today, there are 170 D2C (direct-to-consumer) stores. We are guiding them to look beyond India, at the Middle East and the UK. It is important to internationalise the brand. Today, you

have a big brand in India that is loved in the world of Ayurveda, and it is so relevant here. Also, we see the opportunity for Ayurveda in other parts of the world.

It's not just about the money that we put in. Rather, there is a partnership with insights, guidance and a lot of effort. We have a very long history and that is our biggest trademark. A young entrepreneur comes to us not only because we can do a great product; it's about where to go, how consumers are behaving, what channel to look at, how to market in a world that has transformed remarkably and is digital now. We can bring a great idea at scale very quickly.

Q: You took over the company at a difficult time. What was your mandate?

A: This company has had a long journey and will be around. There is a need to make it more agile and be the best when it comes to being consumer-centric. Innovation is at the core and simplification must be part of how we work. We must touch every single consumer wherever they are. The MoU that we recently signed with the Indian Ministry of Commerce is about promoting women entrepreneurs. Globally, 80% of our workforce is women. In India, it is two-thirds.

Q: You obviously like innovation and what it can do. Can you think of innovation without technology?

A: Technology is playing a much bigger role than ever before. Think about it. There is a big evolution in consumer behaviour. Experience is at the core of everything that the consumer wants. It is not only about the product but also how they interact with it. Technology helps with that. Today, we have a virtual trial for make-up where you can just look at your face through an AI tool on your phone or iPad. Beauty is not just about satisfying a need, it has to go with the occasion—for instance, is it for office or when you step out for dinner?

Technology reduces the pain points, and you will see much more of it. AI allows us to mine this data and bring products in a more meaningful way to the consumer. But technology can't solve everything. It is an enabler but cannot be a replacement for how we create the magic.

In prestige and luxury, one thing that defines us is retention. People come back to our brands over and over again. When you use it, you touch and feel it. That is very important. Our role is not just to meet the demand but also surprise the consumer. **BT**

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